

A Short Story: Frost Fair [C1]

Lo spettacolo del Tamigi ghiacciato trasforma Londra in uno scenario unico, dove una storia di amicizia inizialmente meravigliosa si trasforma rapidamente in un incubo.



In the winter of 1739, the Thames stopped. I refused to believe it, but Martha [dragged me down](#) to the river to see how blocks of ice had formed around the [piers](#) of London Bridge and joined together to make a great [plug](#) that had stopped up the water. A bank of ice [stretched](#) from Southwark to the City. It was an amazing sight! A whole street of tents had [sprung up](#) — each one a shop or a pub. People were walking down the ice as if they were in a city street. Those without shoes tied [rags](#) around their feet, others were on skates. Martha and I stood on the [shore](#), [gaping](#) as strange carriages travelled between the banks: some of the watermen had fixed [sledges](#) to their boats so they wouldn't lose trade. Martha [picked up](#) her skirts and stepped out onto the frozen Thames. "Come back!" I called. I was frightened the ice would open up and [swallow](#) her, but she just laughed. So I followed and, by the time [I caught up with](#) her, my breath was coming out in great, white clouds. Martha [grinned](#) at me and I could see diamonds of ice on her [eyelashes](#). She pointed, and [to my astonishment](#) I saw a tent selling [ale](#), another tent with a printing press selling ballads. One man [was juggling](#). Another had a cart [laden](#) with fruit. An orange [rolled off](#) the cart and, quick as a flash, a boy [streaked out](#) from the shadow of a pier, grabbed the orange and [vanished](#) among the tents. This was the Frost Fair. Apart from fruit-sellers, there were shoemakers, barbers, pie-sellers, three or four pubs, and some very brave prostitutes. There were bowling matches, cart races and dances. Most marvellous of all was a great fire [glowing](#) on the ice with a pig [roasting on a spit](#). It made our stomachs [groan](#) but we had no coins for a slice of pork [in a bun](#). Martha got us some food. She always knows how to use her [wits](#). She told a [lad](#) she'd give him a kiss if he stole her a pie. He did and we shared it, sitting on an [upturned crate](#). Suddenly I heard a strange knocking sound. It came from behind, raced under my feet and disappeared ahead of me. I jumped up in alarm: "What's that noise?" Martha only laughed. "That's nothing. It's just river stuff: [logs](#) and bits of old wood carried along by the river and knocking against the ice." That made me [shudder](#). Whatever it was had passed by so quickly, it made me think of dark rushing waters under the ice. "I might go," I said, trembling. "I'm getting cold." "Don't go yet," said Martha. "I'll see if my new sweetheart can get us some [ale](#) and then we'll have a dance." A few minutes later we both had [mugs](#) of [ale](#) and were dancing with some others to the music of a [fiddle](#). At least Martha was dancing. I just [swayed](#) on the spot and looked around anxiously. That's how I noticed it. There was a fire in front of the tent nearest us and at first I thought the tent was [shimmering](#) in the heat from the [blaze](#). Then I realised that five or six tents were [shuddering](#) and moving up and down. I called Martha, but she was [twirling around](#) with her young [lad](#) and didn't hear me. Other people began to notice. They stopped dancing and looked up. And then, from nowhere, there came a [deafening](#) crack followed by [shrieks](#) of fear as a dozen tents and a whole crowd of people dropped into the Thames. I saw Martha throw up her arms and fall. Then I saw her [clinging](#) to the ice, but the river had caught her skirts and was dragging her under. Our eyes [locked](#) and she called to me. I [dived](#) onto my belly reaching out to her. She raised a hand but was sucked away under the ice. I couldn't breathe —

not as long as Martha was under the water. I [plunged](#) my arm into the icy river, [seized](#) her hair and pulled. I felt her hands [grip](#) my wrist, trying to pull herself up; but she was pulling me down and I began [to slide](#) towards the broken edge of the ice. “Help!” I screamed. “It’s my friend, I’ve got her! Help me!” Suddenly, the [lad](#) who’d got us the pie was on his belly beside me, reaching into the water. Another man came and together we pulled Martha, white and shaking, onto the ice and at last I could breathe! They [wrapped her up](#) and carried her off to the [shore](#) for some gin. I don’t know how I got off the ice myself. I just remember [crawling](#) and crying with relief. I didn’t see Martha for about three days and when she finally [showed up](#) back home, she complained I’d [ripped half her hair out](#). But that was just Martha’s way. Every night for months she dreamed she was back under that ice and she would cry out and [nestle](#) in my arms. She knew I was the one who’d saved her.

Glossary

- **twirling around** = fare una giravolta
- **to slide** = scivolare
- **upturned crate** = cassa rovesciata
- **stretched** = estendersi
- **shore** = riva
- **grinned** = sorridere
- **to my astonishment** = con mio stupore
- **was juggling** = fare giocoleria
- **streaked out** = uscire velocemente
- **roasting on a spit** = arrostitire allo spiedo
- **I caught up with** = raggiungere
- **in a bun** = con il pane
- **lad** = ragazzo
- **mugs** = tazze
- **shimmering** = brillare
- **plunged** = immergere
- **wrapped her up** = avvolgere
- **crawling** = gattonare
- **sprung up** = sorgere
- **vanished** = scomparire
- **glowing** = brillare
- **groan** = gemere
- **swayed** = oscillare
- **clinging** = aggrapparsi
- **locked** = fissarsi negli occhi
- **showed up** = apparire
- **eyelashes** = ciglia
- **sledges** = slitte
- **swallow** = inghiottire
- **laden with** = carico di
- **deafening** = assordante
- **shrieks** = urla
- **grip** = afferrare
- **ripped half her hair out** = strappare
- **ale** = birra
- **fiddle** = violino
- **nestle** = rannicchiarsi
- **dragged me down** = trascinare
- **piers** = moli
- **plug** = tappo

- **gaping** = fissare a bocca aperta
- **wits** = ingegno
- **blaze** = fiamme
- **dived** = buttarsi
- **seized** = prendere
- **rags** = stracci
- **rolled off** = rotolare via
- **shudder** = rabbrivire, tremare
- **picked up** = raccogliere
- **logs** = tronchi